

The Foundation That Saves, the Fire That Tests, and the Mercy Behind Judgment

Open up to 1 Corinthians 3. Hallelujah, Jesus. Or we might back up to chapter 2 and kind of slip up on chapter 3 again, passing in review.

In assimilating the book of Acts, I knew while assimilating it that the day would come when He would finish putting the book together for me. Sometimes it is not the chapters in the same book that cause it to completely open. Sometimes it is chapters in other books that you are assimilating.

When you are assimilating Ephesians, Galatians, or the book of Acts, if you get stuck somewhere in Scripture and are not able to understand it after you are fifty times through, you cannot rush revelation knowledge. A lot of times He has to prepare you and your understanding.

As He builds that foundation and starts putting the building on it, the more you understand, the more you are able to understand. And the more you are able to understand, the more you will understand. Maybe there are some things in that book you cannot clear up because you have not come to an understanding yet.

In the assimilation of the book of Acts, you cannot push it. You have to give yourself over to it and let it happen.

In assimilation, we set some of the rules He taught me early on: I needed to know what each verse said, even if I did not know what each verse meant.

My favorite example is the proverb, "Where no oxen are, the crib is clean." Well, that is nice. Who does not know that? I know what the verse says. I just wonder what He is getting at.

So when I am assimilating, I make sure I understand what each verse says, even if I do not know what it means.

When you go by a judgment like the one that took place with Ananias and Sapphira, I used to just read faster. I would kind of speed up and could not wait for the next chapter. It was something so void of my understanding, especially if I had just come through a season when He had been opening up the love of God. I would think, "Oh boy, who am I reading about here, God or the devil?"

Come to find out, it was finally my understanding of the love of God, deeper than I had ever had it, that enabled me to go ahead and break open those verses on Ananias and Sapphira.

I get the biggest kick out of a friend of mine. I have known him a long time, and when he gets what he would call a new revelation, he will call. So he got through telling me what God had shown him, and he was so excited about it.

Then he said, "Has the Lord shown you anything lately?"

I kind of did a cross reference. I went back, and I could have gone back a little further in Ananias and Sapphira, but I really wanted to torment him. I went ahead with it. I just love to ask people, "What does it mean? What happened to them? Why did God do that?"

Of course, he dug into a message he had heard, which was that there was so much of the glory of God that sin could not enter in. Good statement. And it is true. There was so much of the glory of God there that sin just could not enter into the presence of it.

I said, "That is good. Anything more?"

He said, "Oh yes, it was done as a one-time example to set a pattern for people who would follow."

I said, "Now you are sounding like a theologian."

It is hard to reconcile what happened then with now. With the morals of the church where they are now overall, and where doctrine is going, we are repeating history again if something does not intervene. It is hard to reconcile the morals of the modern-day church with what happened to Ananias and Sapphira. Most churches would be over half empty.

When I started explaining it to him and taking it a little further, I said, "How can God do that if He is no respecter of persons? He judges them while they are alive, and He is going to wait for all the preachers to go home before they get theirs?"

I began to explain that the mantles had come to fullness: the fullness of the love of God, and can you imagine how strong that love had to be?

In a cult, they will threaten you with everything. They will preach and get your money and pressure you until you turn over your wills and deeds. Pressure, pressure, pressure.

But the apostles did not do that. In fact, they informed them, "This was yours. Even after you sold it, you could have done what you wanted with it. Was it not within your power to do that?"

See what happened? There was absolutely free will. These people became one mind, one heart, one soul, and one purpose, so much so that they considered the things that took them an entire lifetime to earn and just laid them down at the apostles' feet. No man considered the things he owned as his own.

That is a real powerful place in the Spirit.

So Ananias and Sapphira were in the baths of love that went over that crowd in unity. They were in it. They had the exact opposite of what they chose. They were not taught by a half-saved preacher who was after their money. They were taught in that atmosphere, and they went totally to the extreme opposite.

They did not just see one wheelchair a year. They saw fields and fields of unclean spirits come out, and the lame, the blind, every kind of disease healed. They were healed, every one.

So when you are sitting under the fullness of an anointing of the love of God and the fullness of an anointing of absolute signs and wonders, and then you go to the opposite end, God is going to have His way.

Those things will come to fullness again. He is going to have His way.

When I first assimilated the wisest man in the world, Solomon, I finally understood what his real problem was. He asked for all the wisdom God had, and he ended up crying, "All is vanity, all is vanity."

As far as a spiritually dead man goes, God can only take him so far. When Solomon asked for everything to make him wise, he partook of everything. His final conclusion was, "All is vanity."

When he took over the throne from his father David, the first thing he did was offer a thousand burnt offerings on the brazen altar in front of the temporary tabernacle his father had built.

A brazen altar is a type of the advocate ministry of Jesus Christ. What Solomon was doing by offering a thousand burnt offerings was this: when he took the throne, he wanted to be clear. If a believer sins, he has an Advocate with the Father, and he can confess it. This is what Solomon was doing. He was cleaning his slate. When he took the kingship, he wanted to be absolutely clean.

If it was cattle, how much would you pay for a good-sized bull? Four or five hundred dollars? If it was five hundred, it would have been a half-million-dollar offering. All that bloodshed could not do what the blood of one single, solitary Man did for us.

God came to Solomon during the night. I think with somebody who does not have a new nature, it is easier for God to communicate with him through dreams. He can sneak in unrelated and get a story over to you.

So Solomon had a dream. In essence, God said, "What do you want?"

He said, "I want wisdom to judge the people righteously."

That pleased God.

And Solomon said, "I want to build You a house." Much of Solomon's temple is still standing. "I want to build You a house."

The more I thought about it, that is what I want to do. Under the shadow, Solomon got as close as he could get to the real in that temple and what it represented. The sinner came. The stranger came. Solomon stood in the temple and prayed:

When they come and stand in Your temple, the strangers, anything they ask You, God, You give it to them so they will know that the Lord God of Israel, He is God.

By the time religion took over, that was not happening anymore. Nevertheless, under the shadow, that type of Christ came to its fullness, and the stranger was accepted.

That is what I wanted. God said, "What do you want?"

I want Your wisdom to judge righteously and understand Your Word. That is what I want. Thank God, I have an offering on the altar.

Guess who it is offering me? The Holy Spirit.

That is why Romans 12 starts, "Likewise you, offer your body a living sacrifice." And if you go back to Romans 8, you find out how to do it. The Holy Ghost offers you up on the altar. When He does, He burns all the flesh out, teaches you the Word, and you become wise.

That is what I want. I want wisdom to judge righteously and to know His Word.

Second, I want to build God a house. Only the real building is made out of the spirits of just men made perfect.

Hallelujah. Thank You, Jesus.

You can understand this building a little bit better. In Peter, he called you lively stones being built up into a habitation of God. The lively stones are laid on the foundation of the apostles, Jesus Christ being the chief cornerstone.

My lively stone is laid on a foundation unlike this old building. This one has wrong doctrine in it. It is falling in. It is not holding up. It is falling in at the corner and falling in over there.

How many love this old building? I can hardly pray in another building. I know that is in my mind. You come in here and you just start. I just love this building.

But the foundation is not exactly laid by the twelve apostles, and the chief cornerstone never falls in, which is Jesus Christ. He said, "Take heed how you build thereon."

So you are one lively stone. Let us read these verses again. Hallelujah.

When we come to the part about whether Ananias and Sapphira went to hell, what do you think most people say? Would I be making a big deal out of it if it was not yes? You are safe. Figure it out. What do most people say?

They say, "Yes. Why would God have done that if they did not?"

But now, when you look back, you think, "Lying over an offering? Die over that?"

I could dictate to you three horror stories right now. I have been overseas where I happened to know how much money was raised for a cause, and I knew how much they got. We are talking over a million dollars for the cause, and a little guy tucked away in a third-world condition got thirty thousand. His cause raised over a million, and the guy who did it is still alive.

When I knew Ananias and Sapphira went to heaven, I also knew I would have to have a strong case.

You are a lively stone, and so am I. We are part of a habitation, a temple that God dwells in, being built by us: the twelve apostles the foundation, Jesus Christ the chief cornerstone. Everything you are, your entire contribution, exists there.

When they mortared the rock and you slipped your stone in and took your place in the temple upon the foundation, what you believe, what you preach, what you teach, and what you are is what your reward is based on.

Paul says in 1 Corinthians 3:9:

For we are labourers together with God: ye are God's husbandry, ye are God's building.

Then he explains it differently:

According to the grace of God which is given unto me, as a wise masterbuilder, I have laid the foundation, and another buildeth thereon.

But let every man be very, very careful how he builds thereupon:

For other foundation can no man lay than that is laid, which is Jesus Christ.

Now if any man build upon this foundation gold, silver, precious stones, wood, hay, stubble;

Every man's work shall be made manifest: for the day shall declare it, because it shall be revealed by fire.

The fire he is talking about is the kind of refiner's fire that burns the dross out of the ore. It is a fire of the Holy Spirit, where He is able to look at your call, you, everything you believed and did, then burn up the trash and see if you have a reward left.

Paul continues:

And the fire shall try every man's work of what sort it is.

If any man's work abide which he hath built thereupon, he shall receive a reward.

If any man's work shall be burned, he shall suffer loss: but he himself shall be saved; yet so as by fire.

I think God's final act of mercy follows me to that day. He said that if everything is burned and there is nothing left, there is still one unchangeable aspect of the foundation that you cannot change. There are other foundational truths, but there is one that cannot be altered.

Jesus said that to enter the kingdom of God, you must be born again. That is the basic, unchangeable foundation that you have to leave intact. You have to have been translated out of darkness into the kingdom of light and His dear Son. You have to be born again.

One time Tim was teaching and said, "Christianity is not a religion. It is a family. You do not join it. You are born into it."

Hallelujah.

Jesus said, "You must be born again." This is the basic, fundamental, foundational truth you cannot alter.

There are other foundational truths, but they can burn. The Holy Spirit and the baptisms are foundational truths. There are several more. You can jump up and preach, "He is not for today. Miracles and healings are not for today," and you can stack all that trash on the foundation. When the refiner's fire comes, all of that will burn. But if you are standing there having been born into the kingdom, you will be saved as by fire.

My whole life, everything that it is, everything I am building and you are building, consists of everything I believe, my works, the foundational truths, my call, and everything He has asked me to do. He takes it all into consideration, and my lively stone makes a contribution to a habitation He is dwelling in.

I am just glad for one thing: the Holy Ghost is my main Teacher, and what He tells me, I will tell you.

Hallelujah, Jesus.

Paul says:

If any man's work shall be burned, he shall suffer loss: but he himself shall be saved; yet so as by fire.

Know ye not that ye are the temple of God, and that the Spirit of God dwelleth in you?

If any man defile the temple of God, him shall God destroy; for the temple of God is holy, which temple ye are.

How many have ever had those verses preached at you when you were born again in an ultra-holiness church and smoked?

"God's temple is holy. Defile it, and God will destroy you."

When I was born again in an ultra, ultra-holiness church, I would try to go, and they would preach such condemnation that I would throw my chewing tobacco out. I never did inhale. I was not as bad as most of you were. I met Grandpa. I got to smoking Grandpa's cigars and chewing his Days Work. It was a nicotine bar about that big.

On Sunday, on the way home from church, I would throw my pipe and chewing tobacco out of the car. Then Monday at noon at work, I would run and get another one.

They used these verses: "If you defile this temple, God will destroy you." To them, drinking, smoking, chewing, and going with girls who do drink, smoke, and chew was the ultimate destruction of the temple.

Even though that is a little fraction of what he is talking about, it is not all. The habitation he is talking about, the one you are building, is the one where you are a lively stone as a contribution. If you destroy the temple, the only way you can do that is by destroying the foundation it is based on. He that takes away Jesus Christ crucified will be destroyed himself.

That is what Paul is talking about. We are talking about defiling the temple and destroying the temple by removing the basic foundation.

He went back in my life to the time I began to survive the time I had committed to God, when I walked off the job as a result of a vision and started praying in tongues. When I started praying in tongues, God started tearing down the building I had built, a stone at a time, and rebuilding His building in its place.

He said in the interpretation:

Where I find you, it does not matter what you believe. If you will loose the Teacher on the inside of you, stone by stone He will pull down and rebuild. He will not leave you the same. He shall receive of Mine and show it unto you.

Therefore yield yourself to Me. For as of yet, many of you understand not the role that I play as He who assists you in offering up yourself as a living sacrifice, saith the Lord.

Hallelujah, Jesus. Hallelujah.

The interpretation of that time took me back suddenly and showed me how far down the trail I was, and yet He was still able to tear it all down and rebuild it, even though I had no teacher except the Holy Spirit, stranded in Oregon.

Hallelujah. I can hardly stand it.

Thank You, Jesus.

When a man is destroyed because he destroys the foundation, we are talking about being destroyed. We are not talking about somebody who totally lost every bit of his reward, or worked absolutely no reward, but was born again and loved God standing there.

Hallelujah, Jesus.

If it takes the defiling of the foundation to be destroyed, I think Ananias and Sapphira were a long way from that. They would not have been hanging around that bunch if they did not love God. The flesh got in, the devil got in, and they just thought they could get by with something.

So God said, "Look, you had probably better come home with Me," and He just took them.

The rest of the time, except for one judgment by Paul, he just turned people over to Satan for the destruction of the flesh because He wanted a repenting time in there. Most of that was because they were beginning the destruction of the foundation of the church, such as Alexander, or the leaven that was getting ready to leaven the church when they were starting to believe adultery was okay. Paul turned that man over for the destruction of his flesh.

If the judgment had been instantaneous, there is a possibility they would have been lost. But it was not instantaneous. The only other instantaneous judgment was when Paul dealt with the sorcerer on Cyprus, in the city of Paphos. When the sorcerer withstood the deputy from being saved, Paul spoke judgment, and he went blind for a season.

What do you want to bet that when he came out of that, he got born again? I mean, you cannot be that way: "Somebody blinded me, but I am not going to serve Him. I am not afraid of Him."

Maybe Ananias and Sapphira were putting a lot of trash on the foundation, but they were not destroying the foundation itself.

Hallelujah, Jesus.

Boy, I am not going to make it near as far as I thought I was.

Let us take this a little bit further. Why don't we skip the fifth chapter for now? Since we have been over that in lesser detail, let us go to the eleventh chapter and look at the thirtieth verse.

The reason I am over here is because, basically, He just will hardly stop talking to me about judgment.

Paul said in verse 29:

For he that eateth and drinketh unworthily, eateth and drinketh damnation to himself, not discerning the Lord's body.

And for this cause - whatever cause was listed - many are weak and sickly among you, and many sleep, or die before their time.

For this cause many are sick among you, and many sleep. What cause? It is in the chapter leading up to that verse.

What is one thing Pentecostal people who believe in healing are always looking for? I forget, Pentecostal is a real old term. I should use more like charismatic. But people who believe in healing are always looking for the reasons why people do not get healed.

In this chapter, when Paul was teaching, he was the opposite. He was more amazed, not that people do not get healed, but that they get sick. He said, "For this reason, many are sick among you, and they sleep before their time."

Pentecostal people were always looking for reasons. This is one of them, and it is related to what he was teaching about judging yourself and different things.

I do not know how many things I have fought off my body, but one thing I made sure of during the fight - before the fight actually, during it, and after it, but especially when the devil would attack and seem to get some ground on me - was that I had absolutely nothing in my heart against anybody else.

I do not care if I had to fast until my britches fell off.

So when Paul says, "For this cause many are sickly among you," he is speaking of a specific cause. It is one of the main ones. But there are a lot of others, such as bad teaching. Usually, when people have teaching that is against healing, and you go into a crusade, they are the first ones God heals because He wants them to know He is not like that, and He is free to heal them because of their unaccountability.

Wrong teaching keeps people from receiving. There are several reasons. But the one here is one of the top ones.

Paul said:

For this cause many are weak and sickly among you, and many sleep.

Resident diseases move in, and they die before their time. But he went on to say:

For if we would judge ourselves, we should not be judged.

There is that word again. He would just as soon have you do it.

If we would judge ourselves, we should not be judged. But when we are judged from not judging ourselves, we are chastened of the Lord so that we should not be condemned with the world.

So when we are judged, either by ourselves or by the Lord, if we will receive it, we will receive chastening from the Lord and will not have to be condemned to die of everything the world dies of.

It would pay us to find out what cause he is talking about, wouldn't it? For this reason many are sick among you, and many sleep before their time.

The thing He has been majoring on is the part we were not understanding. Because the mantle was at fullness in the early church in love and in power, it was also in the fullness of the mantle of judgment. And as you can see, it was wielded because God loved the people, not because He was against them.

He always wanted either to turn them or to remove them from a potential situation where they would have gotten worse. There is no telling where Ananias and Sapphira would have ended up.

When that judgment is to fullness, God always uses it in love.

The other day, I got such a kick out of it. A guy announced that he was Jesus and that he lives in Florida. They interviewed a woman who was sane. She looked nice, dressed nice, and was wittier than the guy interviewing her.

He said, "Do you believe he is Jesus?"

She said, "After one meeting with him, I believed he is Jesus. Oh, he is."

The host was amazed that she would sit there and say that.

You do not know how many people out there have problems, and the devil will tell them they are a character from the Word of God. Institutions are full of them.

Now tell me, what do you think Paul would have done if he was preaching in the same town where they formed their religion? What do you think he would have done when he heard them teach?

He would have said, "Look, you are going to learn not to blaspheme, and let me tell you why you are going to learn."

Even after all of that, it was not too many generations later, after the death of the apostles and the forming of the canon of Scripture, that the church plunged into the Dark Ages. The Catholic Church emerged after a few centuries strong, but today is different.

Today I can sit here and talk to half the world from my front room if I want to. Today is different. People are not living and dying five hundred miles from me over a mountain range that has not been visited by the gospel for thirty or forty years and lost their way.

The media, information, and knowledge are increasing. Everything is heading toward the end. But never before has God had a chance to harvest like He is going to harvest in these last generations to come.

We have media. We have a lot of things they did not have. They did the best they could, but the devil fought every camp individually until he beat them to pieces and drove them back. They did not have the luxury of picking up the Word. They would hang on to the messages they had. There was no recording. They did not have a tenth of the benefit you have, but they came in with the fullness of power.

That is why Paul donated a whole chapter - not to any of the gifts of the Spirit, but a whole chapter on the revelation gift. He that prays in this unknown tongue speaks the mysteries, the understandings of everything He is in you, to you, and through you, the hope of glory.

Praying in tongues is like any other kind of prayer. It is designed by God to be answered, except that when He answers it, you have given Him permission by praying a mystery out to move on your understanding, override everything that is not true, replace it with everything that is, and bring His giftings and direction.

That is why a whole chapter was on that, whereas none of the other gifts of the Spirit got that much attention. This one did, and it was their survival.

But now that we have the instructions written down right in front of us, people still get taken away by our enemy.

How many know that the correct mantle of judgment is going to be prevalent in the last days as He gets the church ready for our return? Fullness of power, the love of God like they had never seen, but also this mantle.

Can you see the millions who will be saved when they see God's hand destroy a false foundation somewhere while giving the same man a chance to be saved? Can you see the power that could be in that?

Myself, and I am truthful when I say this, I hope that is not one of my calls.

You must have a full measure of mercy that rejoices against judgment. Remember, it is wielded by the sword of His love, not vengeance.

Hallelujah, Jesus.

I can hardly understand it.